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ORIGINAL ARTICLE

Alcohol marketing on social media: young adults engage with alcohol marketing on facebook

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ABSTRACT

Background: Young adults are highly-active users of social network sites such as Facebook for their everyday friendship socializing. Alcohol companies have strategically used Facebook to embed their alcohol marketing into young adults' social networking friendship activities, blurring the lines between user and alcohol brand generated content. This study explored mechanisms through which commercial alcohol interests interact with young adults' online friendship practices and how young adults engage with this online alcohol marketing.

Method: Researcher-participant online Facebook interviews were conducted with seven (4 females, 3 males) New Zealand young adults (18–25 years). The interviews were recorded using data screen-capture software to track participants' online navigation and audiovisual recording of the conversation and non-verbal behaviors.

Results: Our social constructionist thematic analysis identified that online alcohol marketing is obscured within friendship endorsing and invitations to drink; taken up as content for Facebook friendship fun; and objected to as intrusions into online friendship activities.

Conclusions: Social media alcohol marketing encourages alcohol consumption through new forms of promotion and the exploitation of networked peer group friendship practices. The interaction between young adults' online friendship practices and alcohol marketers as “friends” inside these practices needs urgent attention by policymakers seeking to reduce alcohol consumption.

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Introduction

Many young people in Western countries deliberately drink to intoxication within a culture of branded consumption, leisure-based lifestyles and liberalized alcohol policies (Babor et al. 2010; Huckle et al. 2012; McCreanor et al. 2008). At the same time, in relatively affluent Western societies, young adults' everyday social lives are highly entrenched within social networking sites (SNS) such as Facebook. Although multi-platform SNS use is increasing (e.g. Twitter, Instagram, Pinterest) Facebook continues to be the most popular SNS globally with the highest percentage of online engagement (Duggan et al. 2015). As well as using SNS for everyday friendship activities, SNS are also firmly embedded within young adults' drinking practices (Atkinson et al. 2016; Carah et al. 2014; Lyons et al. 2014). Many young adults post a high level of alcohol-related content onto their SNS pages such as their drinking party photos (Brodmerkel & Carah 2013; Moreno et al. 2010; Jernigan & Rushman 2014) and they use Facebook to plan and document drinking events through posts and photos (Lyons et al. 2014). This content is then used for interactions and shared humorous post-night drinking stories (Brown & Gregg 2012; Lyons et al. 2014). Within this context, alcohol companies strategically use SNS such as Facebook to promote positive brand

engagement with young adults' drinking activities (Carah 2015; Nhean et al. 2014; Saffer 2015; Purves et al. 2015).

Ninety percent of the top 25 global alcohol brands have active accounts on Facebook, Twitter, and YouTube, averaging 2.6 million Facebook fans, over 11,500 Twitter followers, and over 2.9 million video views (Alhabash et al. 2015). Alcohol companies have invested heavily in social media marketing in recent years to target young adults within their digital worlds. For instance, the largest multinational alcohol (spirits) corporation – Diageo – states: “It is not about doing “digital marketing”, it is about marketing effectively in a digital world” (Diageo 2015, p.20). Another global premium spirits alcohol company – Pernod Ricard – plans to spend at least 25% of its advertising budget to target millennials through social media sites (Hymowitz 2015). The strategy of this marketing is to embed alcohol brands as “friends” into young adults' social networking friendship activities using multiple platforms, real-world tie-ins, and blurring the lines between user and alcohol brand generated content (McCreanor et al. 2013; Moraes et al. 2014; Nicholls 2012).

This blurring of the lines between user and branded alcohol content co-opts young adults' own user content that portrays their cultural and gendered identity-making through their alcohol consumption practices (McCreanor, Greenaway, et al. 2005). For instance, the New Zealand Tui

alcohol brand plays to gendered masculinity through cultural tropes (e.g. get trim in just three minutes a day – yeah right!), humourously capturing salient young male narratives of strength and success that shape their identities (McCreanor, Greenaway, et al. 2005). Young adult male New Zealanders aligned their masculinity with these marketing practices by identifying themselves with the Dominion Breweries alcohol band's allegiance to the “good kiwi bloke” and Steinlager's call to “know who you are”; these masculinity markers were used to signal status, identity and belonging (McCreanor, Moewaka Barnes, et al. 2005). In addition, femininity and age-related identity-making through alcohol consumption was shown by young New Zealand adult males aligning their drinking as “fun and cool” for their age, and classing RTD's (Ready to Drink brands) as “lolly water” for females only, rather than a man's drink like Woodstock bourbon (McCreanor et al. 2008). Overall, these cultural, aged and gendered identity-making youth meanings around alcohol cohere in a pervasive climate of intoxication – an intoxicogenic environment for youth socializing (McCreanor et al. 2008).

Alcohol brands embed identity-making symbolism into young adults' SNS practices and encourage young people to use SNS during real world events through liking, sharing, posting and tagging (Carah 2014). People in these cultural spaces are encouraged to register their experiences by check-ins, status updates and photos from their smartphones (Carah et al. 2014). This engagement generates a form of “brand-building labor” as the brand is taken into young adults' friendship socializing and identity-making practices, allowing brands to be evoked as integral to this sociality (Carah et al. 2014). Further, these brand “activations” create marketing data (e.g. personal demographics, text and images, timings and friendship networks) that may be used to categorize and target “drinkers”; marketers use this sociality as free Labor to activate their brands (Carah 2015). In these ways global alcohol corporations and other alcohol sellers align their alcohol brands with young adults' socializing activities and mimic genuine online interpersonal interactions; merging content with contributions of friends in social media (McCreanor et al. 2013). This infiltration requires research attention because such strategic, heavy embedding of alcohol content within young adults' online socializing practices, normalizes drinking.

The relatively unregulated SNS environment means young people are increasingly exposed to alcohol marketing material (Jernigan & Rushman 2014; Moreno & Whitehill 2015) as companies shift attention and budgets toward cyberspace (McClure et al. 2016). Increased consumer engagement and greater interactivity alter the marketing landscape so young people become active in co-creating and disseminating marketing messages (Dunlop et al. 2016). More of this activity is reaching under-age people. Research highlights that Facebook alcohol marketing content was able to reach 89% of males and 91% of females aged 15–24 in the UK, followed closely by YouTube and then Twitter (Winpenny et al. 2014). A partnership between Google and Heineken to increase the latter's YouTube activity seems set to expose

103 million minors worldwide per month to harmful alcohol marketing (de Bruijn et al. 2016; EUCAM, 2011).

Social media marketing supplements conventional media marketing and may contribute to increases in consumption (Anderson et al. 2009; Saffer 2015). Longitudinal studies of the effects of exposure to conventional alcohol marketing (Anderson et al. 2009; de Bruijn et al. 2012) suggest that engagement with online marketing content is related to increased frequency and amount of consumption. Preliminary research suggests that young people's co-creation of alcohol promotional activities (e.g. liking and sharing activities on branded nightclub pages) may directly influence and encourage consumption (Moraes et al. 2014). In the USA, college students' interactions with social media alcohol marketing (e.g. clicking on alcohol advertisements, receiving alcohol-related updates, downloading alcohol related wallpapers, screensavers, widgets) predicted self-reported problem drinking behaviors (Hoffman et al. 2014). Similarly, Alhabash et al found that viral reach – the volume of view and sharing (“shares”) and affective evaluations (“likes”) – for an alcohol marketing side-bar ad viewed by US college students was associated with higher intentions to consume alcohol. Furthermore young adults' willingness to use Facebook status updates to like, share and comment were strongly related to their intention to consume alcohol when these status updates were strongly “liked” and shared by their peers (Alhabash et al. 2015).

The various ways alcohol marketers use social media (especially Facebook) to communicate with users to co-produce and generate alcohol-related content is known as a form of engagement marketing. Engagement marketing actively involves users in content development and sharing, leading researchers to warn that “alcohol marketing content in social media has the potential to pose even greater risks for promoting alcohol abuse than traditional marketing” (Hoffman et al. 2014, p.333). Alcohol brands use these digital marketing strategies to embed the brand into people's everyday lives through social networking, thus normalizing the daily consumption of alcohol (Nicholls 2012). Studies show that young people openly share alcohol marketing, alcohol-related content and consumption practices through SNS, reproducing valued drinking identities and facilitating the normalization of alcohol consumption (Atkinson et al. 2016; Carah et al. 2014; McCreanor, Greenaway, et al. 2005; McCreanor et al. 2008). Young adults have been found to be skeptical about sponsored (sidebar) advertisements by alcohol companies, but they enthusiastically endorse and engage with alcohol-related Facebook promotions, activities, competitions, sites and posts (Atkinson et al. 2016; Lyons et al. 2014).

Research to date has explored young adults' own meanings and understandings of SNS alcohol marketing through friendship focus groups (Atkinson et al. 2016; Lyons et al. 2015), providing some insights into their SNS norms. This research demonstrates that young people engage with SNS alcohol content in their identity-making and friendship practices (Carah 2014, 2015; McCreanor et al. 2008; Lyons et al. 2015; Niland et al. 2014); suggesting alcohol marketing on social media has the potential to influence young adults' alcohol consumption. For instance, Atkinson et al. (2016) found that young people

used SNS alcohol content as ways to signal their masculine and feminine identities, and engaged with branded music and sporting events, and local venue event marketing particularly through friendship photos at these venues. Their participants, however, drew on a discourse of immaturity to distance themselves from being seen as manipulated by SNS alcohol content. The knowledge of this resistance within SNS alcohol engagement activities was gained by engaging directly with young people's perspectives; listening to them talk about their experiences. To further explore how young people actively make sense of, and engage with SNS alcohol content, our study moves beyond friendship focus groups to interview young people as they interact online with this content in real time.

A disadvantage of friendship group discussions is that they separate participants from their everyday social networking experiences and practices (Davies 2012; Salimkhan et al. 2010). Our online Facebook interview method went toward overcoming this disadvantage by engaging with participants' practices *in situ* and their interpretations of these experiences. The aim of the current study was to undertake an in-depth examination of young adults' interactions with alcohol marketing from within their own social networking practices by interviewing them face-to-face while they were online. We focused on participants' meanings and understandings of the ways in which commercial alcohol interests interacted with their own online practices, and the implications of such interactions.

Methodology

This research takes a social constructionist approach that queries our taken-for-granted knowledge and views social realities as largely achieved through shared practices in particular socio-historical locations (Burr 2003). Language is a social medium through which we enter into shared meanings and, as we learn to use language purposively, it becomes a social tool to constitute our social realities (Bruner 1990). Our focus was on young adults' talk in relation to ways they constructed or made sense of social media practices (involving active use of images and language) including alcohol marketing they came across in this context. Ethical approval for this study was obtained through the University's Human Ethics Committee.

The research reported here is situated within a wider project that explored how young people in New Zealand use SNS within their drinking cultures. The project recruited 141 male (40%), female (57%) and Fa'afafine (3%; this term is used in Pacific cultures for people born male but whose spirit is female) 18–25 year-olds ($m = 20$). Participants were from three ethnic groups – indigenous Maori; those of Pacific Islands ancestry; and Pakeha, of European settler descent – and were diverse in occupation, education, levels of income, and urban/provincial/rural domicile. New Zealand young adults' alcohol consumption patterns are aligned with intoxication patterns in international findings from similar societies (Babor et al. 2010; Rehm et al. 2009). The New Zealand Health Survey (Ministry of Health 2015) showed that 85% of 20–24 year olds drank alcohol in the past year (more than any other age-group) with females less likely to

have done so than males. Pakeha and Maori were considerably more likely to have consumed alcohol in the past year (85% and 80% respectively) than Pasifika at 56%. Of the drinkers, 80% of 20–24 year olds consumed enough to feel drunk at least once in the past 12 months and nearly 20% drank to intoxication weekly, enduring the greatest levels of psychological and physical injuries. Within our overall investigation we were also interested to go beyond these ethnicity statistics, to explore ethnicity cultural practices within young adults' drinking cultures.

In stage 1 of our project, we conducted 34 focus groups (12 Maori; 12 Pakeha; 10 Pasifika) ranging from 3 to 7 participants. Open-ended video/audio-taped discussions focused on friendship, socializing, social networking, and drinking practices, and were analyzed thematically and reported in multiple papers (Lyons et al. 2014; Lyons et al. 2015; Niland et al. 2014; O'Carroll 2013).

A subset of participants then took part in open-ended one-hour individual online "go-along" interviews where they navigated around their Facebook pages and discussed them with a researcher. These 23 interviews also took place with Maori (8), Pasifika (8) and Pakeha (7) participants, and were conducted by three PhD researchers matched to their own ethnicity stream. Within these interviews all researchers explored drinking images and the use of Facebook in drinking cultures, finding that alcohol marketing was embedded within participants' user-generated content for all ethnicities (e.g. "friending" branded pages; sharing product promotions among friends), positioning the marketing as part of the fun, pleasure and socializing of alcohol consumption (Lyons et al. 2014). The researchers then focused on different and more specific aspects of social networking for different doctoral projects. Within the Maori individual interviews participants were asked about their use of Facebook and social media more generally for creating and sustaining cultural relationships with their Maori whanau (families), iwi (community) and hapu (tribe). Within the Pasifika interviews, the focus was social networking among family, church and Pasifika communities. The interviews with Pakeha participants explored aspects of friendship practices and digital alcohol marketing, and focused on what participants had seen and engaged with on Facebook.

A major ethnicity difference for participants' engagement with drinking and SNS was that many Pakeha participants had a tendency to share their drinking practices online with less self-surveillance or reflection than Pasifika and Maori participants who were more likely to voice concerns about their families and communities viewing such content (Lyons et al. 2014). The focus on friendship practices for the Pakeha participants showed that much "friendship and identity work" was required in an intoxicogenic SNS environment (Niland et al. 2014). Given that alcohol brands infiltrate young adults' SNS friendship and identity-making practices (Carah 2014, 2015) we aimed to explore such incursion in more depth by focusing on a small sub-set of participants as they actively engaged with digital alcohol marketing within their online socializing practices.

The seven Pakeha participant interviews form the dataset analyzed for the current paper, because they are intrinsically

of interest, drawn as they are from the cultural group that constitutes the largest and most accessible market for alcohol sellers. They are being targeted primarily by professionals of the same cultural background, within the frame of the dominant culture where both marketers and targets regard alcohol as a naturalized part of sociality. As such these participants' understandings can usefully shed light on the industry thinking and audience response for those interested in reducing consumption in this part of the market. There are practical reasons as well; the Pakeha doctoral project was the one that was most focused on marketing, and provided a manageable-sized data set for a series of analyses.

Method

To explore the potential influences of alcohol marketing on drinking practices, we used an online "go-along" method (Kusenbach 2003) to access young adults' social networking *in situ*. Research suggests alcohol online marketing has the potential to influence young adults' heavier consumption (Alhabash et al. 2015; Hoffman et al. 2014) but exploration is impeded by social desirability and recall bias, interpretations of young adults' SNS pages that excludes their meanings, and the general limitation of correlational studies around causation. With regard to causative analysis, we acknowledge that we cannot predict the impact on young people's alcohol consumption from our data analysis. But our findings can shed light on some of the processes that underlay the positive correlations found in major international studies between young people's exposure to online alcohol marketing and levels of alcohol consumption (Anderson et al. 2009; de bruijn et al. 2012). The value of our small-scale in-depth method is that it allowed us to explore participants' alcohol-related activities on Facebook and how they made sense of alcohol marketing from their own navigations and perspectives.

Our go-along interviews involved participants accessing and navigating their Facebook accounts on an internet-enabled laptop while talking about social networking, alcohol marketing and drinking (Lyons et al., 2015). Participants logged onto their Facebook account and took the researcher on a "tour" showing and elaborating their social networking practices. The researcher asked exploratory questions focusing on social networking and friendship (e.g. What do you do with your friends online?), photo displays (e.g. How do you decide what photos to post?), privacy (e.g. who can see your profile?), advice about Facebook (e.g. what advice would you give people about using Facebook?). The drinking and alcohol online marketing questions included the following: Are there any posted stories, photos and videos that involve alcohol and drinking episodes? What other sites do you visit? Can you show them to me? Do you know of any alcohol-related websites? Do you see much alcohol-related marketing or advertising? What do you think of this alcohol marketing?

Interviews were recorded using video and data screen-capture software. The audio-data for each interview was transcribed verbatim (and anonymised) and used to identify segments in which alcohol marketing was discussed and also present in the screen-capture recording. Our screen-capture

showed all page content as well as cursor movements so we were able to access the full context of data including friends' comments, "likes" and shares. Analysis focused on salient sections of the interviews, screen-capture data and the digital tracking record (shown within square brackets in quotes provided below). We were interested in those elements that participants specifically reacted to as well as other online content that they appeared not to notice or to ignore.

Analytic strategy

An inductive thematic analytic strategy (Braun & Clarke 2006) was used to explore how online alcohol marketing engages with young adults' friendship practices within Facebook. We firstly explored the transcript of each interview focusing on segments where alcohol or alcohol marketing were navigated to by participants. Within these segments we identified common friendship practices (e.g. "liking" posts or posting drinking photos) and common words and phrases participants used to talk about these practices. We derived higher-level themes for these activities (e.g. "shared fun"). We also identified the activities of commercial alcohol marketing in participants' Facebook pages and other sites that they showed us. We attended closely to participants' interactions with these online marketing materials and ways they talked about them. We re-worked and re-analyzed the coherency and relevance of these themes (online friendship practices/online alcohol marketing interactions) through re-readings within and across all transcripts and ongoing discussions, strengthening our analytic procedure.

Results

Participants talked, showed and interacted with their Facebook pages throughout the interviews in live, real time. They checked notifications, read newsfeeds and personal messages, viewed and "liked" photos, accepted invitations, commented on posts, responded to chat messages, accepted friend requests and clicked on and shared posted links. When specifically asked whether they saw alcohol advertising in Facebook, most participants responded "no" except Sarah who showed the Vodka Cruiser page ("It tells you when they've brought out a new brand of alcohol or a new flavor or things like that so there are some advertisements..."). All participants also indicated that Facebook advertising was the sponsored sidebar ads on their Newsfeed pages as demonstrated in their quotes below:

Loren: Um no I don't think there's actually anything that advertises alcohol on Facebook. I've never seen anything like that before. It's mostly just like sponsored [hovers cursor over *Sponsored side-bar ads*].

Jane: Um no. Don't think I have. These are the ads that come up normally [hovers cursor over *Sponsored side-bar ads*]. These sort of things. Yeah I don't think I've seen any like Tui [NZ beer brand] ads or anything in Facebook before.

John: Nah. What have I got here? [scrolls *Sponsored side-bar ads*] I've got WelTech [technical college] and Quitline [quit smoking program] and Green Reef Casino.

Rose: No I don't notice it. I think if I did see any I'd be aware of it.

PN: And how do you think they would advertise to you if you if it was there?

Rose: Um it would come up down this side [points cursor to *Sponsored side-bar ads*] here cause it's where ads come up now and again.

Paul: Nah. What have I got here? There's Thirsty Liquor Porirua [points cursor at this alcohol seller ad in *Sponsored side-bar ads*]. That's one. I guess.

Chris: No not actually any alcohol advertising not so much. These [scrolls *Sponsored side-bar ads*] are normally like the main advertisements you see on Facebook.

PN: What do you think of as advertising?

Sarah: These things [hovers cursor over *Sponsored side-bar ads*].

In contrast to this reported absence of alcohol advertising, our thematic analysis identified three prominent themes that captured interactions between alcohol online marketing in Facebook and participants' online friendship drinking practices, namely "friendship endorsements and invitations", "shared friendship fun" and "intrusions into friendship activities". Across these themes we observed recursive interactions between young adults' online practices and alcohol marketers acting as "friends" to become embedded in young adults' social lives. These themes reveal particular ways that alcohol online marketing is (1) sometimes obscured within friendship endorsing activities (e.g. "liking") and invitations to join drinking events; (2) sometimes identified as marketing but taken up and used as content for having fun on Facebook; and (3) sometimes resisted as intrusions into online friendship activities. These themes are described in detail below using quotes as exemplars of each theme.

Online alcohol marketing embedded in friendship endorsements and invitations

This theme shows how the presence of alcohol marketing on Facebook was obscured because it was part of routine friendship activities such as giving/receiving endorsements and invitations. Participants were highly engaged with their friends as they navigated their Facebook pages. A dominant activity in this engagement was "liking" their friends' photos, comments, posts, and links, consistent with previous research (boyd & Ellison 2007; Larsen 2007; Zhao et al. 2008). This suggests a strong imperative to "like" and be "liked" on Facebook, to be recognized as popular and connected – a highly valued activity for young adults (boyd 2006; Livingstone, 2008; Hong et al. 2012). Alcohol venue page photos and activities were also 'liked' by our participants but they did not interpret these activities as marketing, rather as activities embedded within their friendship practices of endorsing each other. This is demonstrated in the excerpt below where the researcher (PN) asks Chris to

show her the links to a bar called Loftus that he had talked about.

PN: Can we have a look at Loftus?

Chris: We can. Loftus Room, Courtenay Place.

[Navigates to Loftus page from within Facebook. Page opens with image of dancing crowd of young people and DJ's hands above a turntable with the accompanying text: "[capital city's] hottest, most popular nightclub. A door in a popular wall, you would never know..." There is an electronic map of the location and contact details. 19 of Chris's friends like the club.]

I haven't liked it but I will cause it's all good.

[clicks LIKE].

[pause 4] Obviously for an example [pause 5] I like.

[hovers over the LIKE dialog box]

Chris: It says "You like Loftus Room. Help your friends discover great places by visiting or writing a recommendation for Loftus Room". See look. Marketing eh? [disparaging tone] They're all about it. I just wouldn't have the time. I'd be like no thanks.

[clicks "No thanks" to decline to comment. Box closes]

In this excerpt, Chris briefly scans the materials visible on the page and immediately moves to "like" the page (which will now appear in the pages of all of his friends including the 19 that already "like" Loftus Room). Following this he immediately receives a message in response to his action, requesting that he write a recommendation. This completes one cycle of the marketing process but the additional request provokes a seemingly critical moment in which he identifies this as marketing and articulates resistance to this extension of his engagement. His reaction is then to click "no thanks" closing the second loop and perhaps unwittingly providing the marketer with further valuable information. Chris is an interesting example of someone with insider knowledge of social media marketing and a philosophical position that constructs his identity as a competent, self-determining online actor. These appear to work together to constitute one form of marketing as obscured from view in the regular practice of "liking" things on Facebook, while the other is viewed as more like marketing manipulation. This highlights how engaging in particular interactions with online alcohol marketing (when Chris clicks "like" for the bar) from venues are viewed as friends socializing together; sharing drinking occasions and "it's all good" but the next interaction with online alcohol (asking for recommendations) is perceived as explicit alcohol marketing that is rejected as somehow demeaning and a waste of his time. A key insight here is that even for Chris (experienced and knowledgeable around social media marketing), "liking" alcohol-related content is not necessarily viewed as a form of marketing. The Facebook "like" option may be routine and part of Facebook activities that it is not perceived as direct marketing. It is notable that clicking the "like" button gives the Loftus Room Chris's profile and friend information; a means to gather a

huge amount of data on potential customers, and then tailor its marketing in sophisticated ways.

In contrast, Sarah seemed to have little awareness of the marketing dimensions of spaces she engaged with in social media. She explained that she has “liked” the Vodka Cruiser page, has won promotional materials and follows the posts to their Facebook page as well as receiving posts directly from them. Her allegiance and interactions with a branded alcohol page – Vodka Cruiser – contrasted markedly with the other participants who did not do this. Sarah navigated to the Vodka Cruiser Facebook page and describes it in the following way:

Sarah: Yeah. I’m not sure where I put it on my page but this is people who have posted pictures of their own drinking.

[Scrolls about within the Vodka Cruiser page. The cursor hovers over pictures, clicks one which immediately loads up – a photo of a woman’s bust (only) in a black t-shirt with an image of four brightly-colored (orange, yellow, green, red) Cruiser products/flavors over the slogan “Great Cans”]

This is what I drink. These size cans. I drink that one.

[cursor points to red can]

PN: Oh ok. What’s that one called?

Sarah: The raspberry one.

PN: Raspberry.

[cursor hovers over fine print on can]

Sarah: Mm. And they’re [pause 2] eight per centers ...

[now reads other people’s posts from page]

“So keen to try these. This is the top I wore for my twenty-first.”

[an accompanying comment also says “Talk about great advertising for you. I’m going to pick up a box on the way home from work!”]

See somebody’s posted this picture.

[Other posts here say “Awesome top!! Where did you get it?”. The original poster replies “[Store name] Liquor Store ... spent like \$150 lol”. New posts several days later add “I have this on a singlet”; “I have one of these too!” in a conversational string. This is followed by a prompt for the participant to write a comment on her page, which she has not done at the point of interview]

PN: Right.

Sarah: Yeah. I’ve tried that one.

[hovers cursor over the pink can]

And I think I’ve tried that one as well.

[hovers cursor over the orange can and then over the the green can]

SarahUm oh I think I might buy that one this weekend. Cool Lime. Yum. [laughs] Going out this weekend.

Finding the t-shirt image she has been searching for Sarah indicates in a positive, emphatic tone that this brand is her first choice of alcohol drink. She is vaguer about the actual names of the products and uses cues from the images to provide further information.

Next her own narrative is briefly interrupted as she reads out the comments from her Newsfeed which appear as part of her regular flow of messages and are therefore presumably from friends. Although she does not read out the other posts she is aware of them and the cursor passes over several before she makes a kind of summary explanation about the post of the t-shirt image. It is not clear what her uptake of the unsaid messages is but they are variously enthusiastic and humorous about the t-shirt and one signals a clear intention to buy the alcohol. Sarah returns to her narrative about her experience of the drink before noting a flavor she has not yet tried, and then resolves, in what might be thought of as another kind of interaction with online alcohol marketing, to buy it for consumption in the weekend ahead. This demonstrates how online marketing materials are linked to a person’s expressed “intention to purchase” the product.

This theme also shows the presence of online alcohol marketing was also sometimes obscured when it was used within friendship group activities, particularly invitations to join drinking events. The interactive activities on alcohol brand and venue pages (e.g. photos, comments, posts, shares) were also not interpreted by participants as advertising when these activities were viewed as invitations or invitations to participate in friendship group drinking displays. Participants’ Facebook activities in relation to drinking were predominantly centered on Facebook photos. Overwhelmingly these images depicted them smiling and laughing with friends, drinking at social events such as sports tournaments, music concerts, restaurants, bars and clubs. Research shows that Facebook portrayals of drinking and drinking activities are not simply routine depictions of pleasurable drinking experiences, but rather a way for young adults to identify with, connect to, and reinforce their friendship group relationships (Niland et al. 2014; Tonks et al. 2015). The participants’ viewed alcohol marketing on venue pages not as alcohol advertising, but as prompts for friends to drink together. This is demonstrated in the following excerpt:

PN: Ok and um so what about events like do you? Like music events? Or anything like that?

Jane: Do I go to any of them? Or do I? I can get them? Yeah through Facebook they invite you. Or people can invite you um

[clicks on “Jane”->profile page\timeline]

Um to them like I think there was one in here before.

[clicks on Friend Requests\See All Friend Requests]

See all friend requests. Here’s one here. When it comes up.

[Friend Requests\You have 2 group invitations\two group invitations display]

This one. Um it's a [pause 3]

[her male friend has invited her to "S-bar Marion" for "Bonkers Thursdays"]

See um DJ concert thing. Yeah.

PN: Yeah. Oh ok.

Jane: So I got invited to that and I probably might come

[clicks on Confirm->You are now a member of "Bonkers Thursdays@S-Bar Marion"].

PN: Oh ok so do you have any alcohol company related invites to things that you notice?

Jane: No.

Jane reiterates her experience of being unaware of advertising in Facebook expressed by other participants but readily acknowledges that she gets invitations to events from both commercial interests and friends. She navigates to a specific invitation that she remembers having received, opens it up and scanning the content explains that it is to a "DJ Concert thing". This is her interpretation of what can be seen on the page which is an invitation to a more generic event called Bonkers Thursdays at the S-Bar venue, suggesting that she is familiar enough with the scenario to characterize it more fully as a music event. Explaining to the interviewer that she may attend, she clicks on the link and receives notification that she is now a member of the page thus completing the marketing circuit in real-time in the interview. Jane responds negatively to the interviewer's probe about alcohol-related promotions, which strongly implies that her understanding of the promotion she has just participated in is as a music event her friend has invited her to, and not a form of alcohol marketing related to a licensed venue. For the S-Bar venue, Jane's membership of their page gives access to her profile and friend information, allowing her data to be available for analysis and hence more targeted marketing.

Online alcohol marketing used by participants to have shared friendship fun

The second theme shows how online alcohol marketing was explicitly employed by participants as part of having fun with friends and friendship groups on Facebook. Participants showed many activities such as posting jokes, comments, photos and video clips that they described as having fun with friends. This is congruent with research that shows young adults create amusements with their face-to-face friends online (Niland et al. 2014). Facebook provides easy, fun ways of networking so that with just a click of a button such as "share", friends can circulate humorous materials. Our data show diverse ways in which alcohol marketing capitalizes on such friendship practices by appropriating memes

and creating promotional elements through humorous alcohol-centered content. While our participants acknowledged that such content constituted alcohol promotion, it was understood primarily as shared fun among friends as the following excerpt (where Paul is asked if he sees alcohol advertising online) demonstrates:

Paul: Yeah. No but I don't really see a lot of advertising online. I'll show you.

[scrolls his Newsfeed posts including a "like" that he did for Silverspoon who wrote "Waiting so long for the weekend then getting so wasted you can't remember it"]

I'll show you something on video.

PN: So you don't see any typically.

Paul: No. This is funny

[scrolls his own posts]

Where is it?

[He finds out what he is looking for, a post that he has titled "Quality ad", which has a link to a video and an explanation (pasted from the website from which he copied the video link): "Carlsberg stunts in Belgium with 148 bikers in a movie theater. Some innocent couples want to take their seat, but the room is filled with not-so-friendly guys ..."]

[He clicks on a YouTube link that plays a clip of tough-looking men sitting in movie theater (Rise of the Planet of the Apes is billed outside) and the reaction of each well-dressed (perhaps middleclass) couple that enters when they see them. A graphic shows "only 2 seats left" and only one couple actually dares to take the seats and sit down. They are raucously applauded and given a Carlsberg beer each]

And it's a Carlsberg ad and they give them a beer.

[4 people have "liked" this post on his page]

In this excerpt, the dimension of user-generated activity is on display. Paul has claimed that alcohol advertising online is not common and here he proceeds to show the interviewer an example that amused him and that he posted to his friends' pages. This suggests that he does not view online marketing as "advertising", but rather as funny user-generated content to share with friends. He has imported (from another site) the link to the branded, presumably commercially produced clip from YouTube and placed it on his page along with his endorsement or encouragement for all in his network (more than 800 people) to watch it. His brief explanation seems entirely uncritical and he seems well satisfied with the tenor of the ad – suspense over the apparent class/culture tension (tough looking bikers versus middle-class couples), resolved by the brand. The four "likes" he has received mean that his post will now appear on the timeline of all of the friends in the networks of those who have responded, thus spreading Paul's original post more widely.

While this segment does not represent alcohol marketing in a conventional sense it does demonstrate how the

affordances of Facebook can rapidly (if unpredictably) expose large numbers of people to marketing materials that include alcohol content. The scenario demonstrated here shows the company's material is continuously passed through various platforms, posted to YouTube for public consumption, rebroadcast from both a commercial site (where Paul found it) and Paul's Facebook page and then reposted to the pages of four of his friends.

John differs from most of the other participants, as he is critically aware that sharing funny content of sports and concerts with his friends in Facebook is linked to visible alcohol sponsorship. He identifies that the Rugby Sevens (rugby tournament) and Bay Watch (music festival) are forms of alcohol marketing via sponsorship. However his tone is quizzical as he searches for materials and puzzles over what they mean; the sense is that he knows that alcohol marketing is present but does not see it as any cause for concern:

John: Yeah

[clicks on the Bay Watch photo/home page]

I mean you think there would be [pause] on the web page. Sponsored by any? I mean there was probably Jim Beam I think cause they had a Jim Beam sound stage there. Um but there's nothing on [pause] oh there we go, Jim Beam Soundshell [a music stage venue].

[clicks on Soundshell image which is branded with Jim Beam. There is a thumbnail for a video of Bo and Bic Runga [New Zealand musical artists] sitting at a picnic table with a can of V [guarana energy drink] between them. And another with a banner in the background saying "More than a handful since 1930" in front of a crowd of scantily clad female revelers. Below in text is the legend "Sun, surf, hotties, great music. Getting down with your crew, camping by the beach...", an explanation of BW's [Bay Watch] association with R&V [Rhythm and Vine musical festival] which is described as the "dopest party of the year" and a description of the "Jim Beam Soundshell". Posts give updates on the BW "lineup", the announcement of an extra 1000 tickets and that the BW site has 19,162 friends...]

PN: Did they have lots of Jim Beam for sale?

John: No. (sounds surprised) Not... except for at, at the Soundshell, but other than that it's just kind of everything. It's quite funny. Um.

In this excerpt, John navigates from his own Facebook page to that of Bay Watch to specifically identify the Jim Beam sponsorship as an exemplar of this form. Although he does not discuss them, the space is populated with celebrities, encouragements, markers of popularity (19,162 friends), sexual innuendo, and detail about the sponsorship, so visitors to the page are certainly exposed to the marketing. John acknowledges that the sponsor's product is on sale at the Sound Shell (music venue) but signaling ("just kind of everything") that this is generally a thoroughly saturated alcohol environment. Elsewhere in the interview he clearly describes how alcohol is freely available from supermarkets adjacent to the venue ("You can just buy a bottle at the supermarket and um you can't take it in to Rhythm and Vines but the

campgrounds"). John views this material as alcohol marketing, and appears to accept it is part of these music festival environments. This is an example of strategically embedding an alcohol brand within young people's music venue social experiences and continually re-enacting it through social media (the Bay Watch page) as Diageo has strategized to do (Diageo 2015).

Online alcohol marketing as intrusions into friendship practices

As the preceding two themes demonstrate, Facebook's provision of a friendship space for young adults affords alcohol companies a powerful way to embed their products within friendship practices. Yet our third theme shows that some of our participants also actively resisted and rejected these friendship penetrations. These resistances were not objections to alcohol marketing per se. When branded alcohol pages (rather than alcohol venue pages) were involved, participants viewed them as intrusive and outside their friendship practices. The following excerpt exemplifies this resistance when Loren shows the researcher a branded alcohol page:

PN: Ah ok. So how come you're not friends with them?

Loren: Cause I don't really support that stuff. I only drink it. I wouldn't go on like support their page.

PN: Why not?

Loren: Cause I just wouldn't. I think it's stupid.

PN: Ok. Why is it stupid?

Loren: I don't know I just have. I don't know. I guess different ... I don't really like signing up to groups because you get so much spam on your page as well. Like "this like person typed in Absolut Vodka" or "this person did this" and then everybody looks through your page and the groups that you're attached to and ones that don't mean anything. Like why are they there? Do you know what I mean?

Like other participants, Loren has reported that advertising is not a feature of her Facebook experience and is limited to sponsored materials in the sponsored side-bar ads. Yet whether on her own pages or elsewhere, she has clearly seen some examples of the nuanced approaches to alcohol marketing that are emerging. Despite being a drinker, Loren expresses strong dissent from online engagement with brands (but not to alcohol branded venues as when she showed a video of herself in a bar: "I was having a shot out of an ice sculpture. At a bar and it was a Vodka shot. It was really funny..."), objecting because she claims such activity is "stupid" and cites pragmatic and privacy issues as salient. She caricatures unwanted messages as trivial and irrelevant and notes that engagement encourages unspecified others to scrutinize her pages and linkages in ways that are unnecessary or inappropriate. She also views belonging to these branded pages or groups as "ones that don't mean anything" suggesting they are irrelevant to her friendship connections on Facebook.

Posts/interactions with alcohol brands (but not venues) were also resisted, not because they were advertising alcohol, but because they were seen to be using and manipulating friendship practices (such as “liking”) to spread their message. The following extract demonstrates this for Tui – a New Zealand beer brand:

Rose: And people are liking them and commenting and I’m sure I’ve got friends.

[clicks on the Tui page]

Let’s see.

[hovers over the Tui\timeline\You and Tui\21 friends like this]

Yeah twenty-one. Twenty-one of my friends like Tui. Like this page.

[looks at PN, scrolls the page, revealing a promotion of the online Tui survey in which the “Tui Girls” are trying to find out “what makes you tick”. Inducement of a year-long Tui “Prize Pack” of beer]

PN: So that means Tui’s got an account?

Rose: Yeah so they’ve got, they’ve created their own Facebook account and they’re just updating it. It’s quite, you know it’s, it’s clever. You know because they’re [pause 1] they’re drawing people into this and then we, when my friends you know, like some update that Tui does, like this.

[cursor on photo of Tui Billboard ad “Captain I know a short-cut to the port”(a reference to the NZ sinking of the Russian cruise-liner Mikhail Lermontov, in 1986) 948 likes, 60 shares, 399 comments –]

You know, new advertisement, then it comes up on my newsfeed, you know and so it’s a way of getting spreading the word, you know getting their message out there.

Rose explains exactly how the Facebook affordances around “liking” of commercial pages operate to draw in people who have not even joined the product page. There is a tone of implicit complaint because even though she herself is not a friend of the Tui site, a conscious resistance on her part, she gets frequent traffic from it because her friends are. The cross-linking of all the pages of friends in an individual’s network is such that the activities of a single connection are shared with all of the others in the friend list. Rose has 21 friends in common with the Tui page so that the potential for her getting posts via this mechanism is high, given the deliberate targeting of young men with sexist, off-the-wall, laddish humor of the Tui campaigns. While this insight is available to anyone with an interest or working knowledge of how Facebook operates, it is also relevant to policy considerations as it shows how this marketing operates. This resistance is significant because it represents both a media-savvy and principled objection to exposures to online alcohol marketing even in its more subtle forms. As such it is a rare standpoint within our dataset but important when considering how public health and other policy frameworks might respond to the growing presence of alcohol marketing on social media.

Discussion

Our data and analyses begin to open up some of the ways in which alcohol marketing on social media “flies under the radar” of media savvy, socially active, technologically connected young adults (Brodmerkel & Carah 2013; Carah 2015; McCreanor et al. 2008). The research demonstrates a number of interactions with online alcohol marketing where participants, in the data collection process, engaged in real time with online alcohol marketing (Nhean et al. 2014; Nicholls 2012; Winpenny et al. 2014). These interactions with online alcohol marketing reveal three key findings that contribute to insights regarding the powerfully entrenched nature of alcohol brand and venue activity within young adults’ everyday social networking. Participants’ online navigations and ongoing talk about the screen content and activity demonstrated that online alcohol *venue* (rather than branded) marketing was obscured within both Facebook friendship endorsements and invitations to friendship group drinking events. Online alcohol marketing was at times identified as advertising but taken up by participants and shared, as a way of having fun with friends on Facebook. Some participants objected to this material as an intrusion into online friendship activities, and it was notable that this referred to branded alcohol social media pages rather than alcohol venue pages.

These findings demonstrate ways in which the alcohol industry embeds marketing “inside” young adults’ online friendship activities, and becomes obscured, taken-up, or rejected within these practices (Alhabash et al. 2015; Carah et al. 2014; Moraes et al. 2014). These strategies are normalized in Facebook and consequently the marketing is “hidden in plain sight”, not disguised or subliminal but overlooked (McCreanor et al. 2008) in the mundane run of material flowing through social media and in the routine and ordinary activities (such as “liking” a page) that users engage with on Facebook (Carah et al. 2014; Hoffman et al. 2014; Nicholls 2012). In this regard alcohol venue marketing rather than brand marketing appears to be more effective in infiltrating young people’s social media activities. It is less likely to be seen as marketing by young people and it is less subject to regulation (Brodmerkel & Carah 2013). This adds to the already diverse challenges of minimizing the harms from increased consumption that are associated with exposure to overt alcohol marketing. In the Facebook environment this marketing by alcohol venues is generally not widely regarded with concern by users.

The architecture and software of Facebook is “hidden” from view and it may constrain, enable and shape people’s interactions (Beer 2009; Van Dijck 2013). This digital architecture has become tangibly and socially integrated into everyday lives in a manner that means commercial presence is “always on”. As people engage with these technologies they become embedded “inside” their interactions with other users, constituting and influencing ways in which users enact and interpret their online social relationships. This perspective highlights how commercial interests may use social technologies to engage with young adults. Alcohol companies “reach out” to young adults through social networking, and,

in turn, young adults “appropriate” particular features in these commercialized relationships (van Dijck 2013). Commercial entities that engage in such interactions acquire a wealth of consumer data from social media users that can be utilized to develop targeted marketing of their products; see Diageo’s multi-million dollar advertising deal with Facebook (Bradshaw 2011). For instance, to click a “like” button on Facebook gives access to people’s “demographics such as location, age, gender and language [and] other traits such as level of education, if they have children, are recently married or even if they own a home” (Facebook 2015, para.5). Facebook has revealed it uses up to 98 pieces of information about its users for targeted advertising (https://www.facebook.com/ads/about/?entry_product=ad_preferences).

Basic surveillance data regarding alcohol online marketing activities is not routinely collected but is essential to be able to identify and implement effective alcohol policies (Mosher 2012). Monitoring social media alcohol marketing, and imposing further restrictions, is strongly recommended by researchers (Winpenny et al. 2014). Many further recommend a complete ban on alcohol promotion on SNS like Facebook, including the UK House of Commons Select Committee (Nicholls 2012; Moraes et al. 2014). Our findings further demonstrate how alcohol marketers “reach out” to young adults from “inside” their online friendship practices, and this coercive interaction also needs to be addressed within alcohol policies.

There were, however, resistances to alcohol marketing. For some, it was not interpreted as “advertising” but as an irrelevant intrusion into friendship activities and manipulating friends’ “liking” to spread its messages through friendship networks. This finding offers a key implication for alcohol-health initiatives. These initiatives can intervene in online intoxicogenic environments by reflecting these interactions with online alcohol marketing back to young adults to give them the opportunity to be more reflexive and critical about their engagement with alcohol marketing.

Alongside the strengths of our go-along interview method, limitations include recognizing that a researcher’s presence may disrupt an informant’s everyday online friendship socializing experiences so that disclosure levels may be suppressed (Kusenbach 2003). Further, while our participants were positioned as guides to their Facebook activities they may have also censored their talk and online activities to portray a particular “self” (Flick 2009) to a researcher. It is recognized therefore that our method captured a particular version of their online worlds, and it would be beneficial to include friendship focus group discussions on these topics (Atkinson et al. 2016) to extend our insights into their interactions with online alcohol marketing. This was also a very-small study that focused on the processes that underlie young adults’ interaction (and engagement) with digital alcohol marketing content. Although it is highly exploratory and findings cannot be generalized, the processes identified here are informative and could usefully be explored in future research with larger and more diverse samples.

Conclusions

Our small-scale in-depth qualitative methodology offers a way to explore young adults’ engagement with online alcohol marketing within their own drinking cultures and digital worlds. Our findings demonstrate in more depth the overall project findings that branded products were embedded within participants’ user-generated Facebook content, reinforcing alcohol marketing as part of the fun, pleasure and socializing of alcohol consumption (Lyons et al. 2014). This infiltration is highly relevant to policymakers seeking to reduce young people’s alcohol consumption. Social media marketing of alcohol is likely to encourage consumption through new forms of promotion (particularly through alcohol venues online), the exploitation of networked peer group friendship practices, and perceptions of the behavior of others. Alcohol venues engage with young adults within their drinking occasions and experiences and this is a highly effective way to infiltrate their everyday socializing, is less subject to regulation, and less likely to be seen as marketing.

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